to darker skins in the extreme south is fairly evident. This would be in line with the theory of the evolution of skin colour, especially if there was some evidence of humans originating in the Indian subcontinent, some sort of a *swayambhu* moment of self-creation that is routinely attributed to the emergence of unexplained divine shrines in India. For the moment, however, the 'out of Africa' hypothesis and the subsequent migrations, some 80,000 years ago, to Europe and Asia and from there to Australia and the Americas, is a more compelling narrative backed by archaeological and genetic evidence.[8] These migrations have inevitably been attributed to climatic changes, little ice ages and shallower or frozen seas enabling crossings between seemingly unconnected lands.

It is such genetic evidence in India that now clearly points to two divergent populations ancestral to the majority of the present-day population, providing clues to the colour gradient and much more.[9] As one landmark 2009 study in the scientific journal *Nature* argued, 'the "Ancestral North Indians (ANI)", are genetically close to Middle Easterners, Central Asians, and Europeans, whereas the other, the "Ancestral South Indians" (ASI)', are as distinct from ANI and East Asians as they are from each other.' The study also shows the mixture between the ANI and ASI groups, such that 'groups with only ASI ancestry may no longer exist in mainland India'. Two small groups consisting of tribes in the Andaman Islands in the Bay of Bengal—the Onge and Great Andamanese—were found to be genetically related to the ASI group but had no traces of ANI ancestry.

The difference between ANI and ASI is by definition, couched in genetic terms, but on the surface it reveals a broad north–south divide in Indian culture and language, running roughly through central India, with the word 'Indo-European' used for the north and 'Dravidian' used for the south. The big question for the Indians then is on the origins of the ANI and ASI groups. This has partly been framed in competing terms on the question of the Aryan migration in the north, linked as it is to the question of the origins of the culture revolving around the Vedas, a collection of hymns and religious texts dated between 1500 BCE (Before the Common Era) to 500 BCE and sacred to the Hindus who comprise around 80 per cent of the